

- Perform due diligence
- Check for permits and perform a title check
- Go through loan underwriting and lock in your interest rate
- Understand the appraisal process
- Close on your new home!

FIRST THINGS FIRST

The very first order of business is to let your lender know you're under contract. Double-check that your lender has all the documents they need, and if they're missing anything, get it to them as soon as possible. Your financial fate is in their hands.

If you didn't contact a home inspector when you made the offer, that's step number two. Schedule the home inspection as soon as possible, and make plans to be there so you can talk to the inspector. Your agent should be able to recommend a good inspector.

Read any HOA documents, if applicable. The HOA covenants, conditions, and restrictions (CCRs) are the rules that govern the community. These can usually be found by searching online for the name of the neighborhood, the city in which it is located, and the term "HOA." The only time you can object to these rules is *before* you purchase the home, and the only way to object is to not buy the home. Once you buy a house in the neighborhood, you are required to follow those rules, no questions asked.

Most CCRs are dozens of pages long. They are dry. They are boring. But you need to know what's in there. Not only do the documents detail the rules, they also detail the remedies, including fines and even litigation. Read them in advance to make sure you actually want to be bound by them. This should be one of the first things you do because it costs nothing, and if you find rules you disagree with, you want to do so before paying for a home inspection or appraisal.

If the CCRs are acceptable, check out the health of the HOA itself. What do the financials look like? How much money are they collecting, and how much of it is going into an account to pay for future common-area repairs? What is their current amount of reserves, when was their last major expenditure, and what is the next planned repair? One of the main benefits